THE GILDED PRINCES

On a perfect day in November 1573, as winter conjured up a high blue sky, the four-year-old prince Salim sat cross-legged in front of a distinguished audience in his father's court. A Koran was placed on the prince's lap, and his newly appointed tutor, Maulana Mir Kalan, led the Bismillah prayer, 'In the name of the gracious, merciful God. The Merciful One taught the Koran.' Immediately the waiting nobles broke into raucous cheers and the 'assembly erupted in such a roar of congratulations that the foundation of the assembly hall shook'. Mir Kalan then lifted the young prince onto his shoulders as the gathered noblemen threw coins into the air and roared out their approval. This short ceremony marked the beginning of Salim's formal education and Akbar had ordered that all the noblemen be present at this momentous occasion.

This resplendent gathering in Fatehpur Sikri was, in its essence, vastly different from similar occasions in Akbar's childhood. The nobility now present included not only Chaghatai and Uzbek Turanis but increasingly Persians, Indian shaikhzadas, Rajput Hindus, Indian Muslim clerics, Chishti descendants, Barahas, and Hindu Kayasthas. Reflecting this new melange of men and styles, the courtiers were dressed in costumes that derived from the accommodating genius of Akbar, who had designed a court dress that both unified and distinguished the men. Under earlier Muslim dynasties, Hindu men of rank at court were obliged to wear the costumes of Muslim noblemen, often leading to resentment. Akbar, on the other hand, designed the jama, probably using an earlier indigenous style called the takauchiya, 'a coat without lining of the Indian form'. These garments were tightly fitted up to the waist and then flowed out in a full skirt with tight sleeves, paired with churidars or payjamas. The Hindus and the Muslims wore jamas which subtly yet easily told them apart—the Muslims wearing the jama with fastenings under the right armpit and Hindus with fastenings under the left armpit. In this way any inadvertent faux pas of etiquette or courtesy was averted while maintaining outward uniformity.

Akbar also proposed a style of jama which, instead of having a straight hem at the bottom, had four pointed ends which could be tucked into the